

VISAKHAPATNAM

A CAPITAL GETS READY

Meanwhile, the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) is eager to complete the relocation by the year-end, signalling its commitment to decentralised development. This is with an eye on the 2024 summer elections to the Lok Sabha and state legislative assembly. By opening the Chief Minister's Office in Visakhapatnam ahead of the mass move, Jagan aims to demonstrate his unwavering resolve to the decision. The three-capital plan was conceived with the hope that the spread of governance activities would stimulate equitable development across Andhra Pradesh, with Amaravati retaining its role as the legislative capital and Kurnool designated as the judicial capital.

The decision comes at a time when the rival Telugu Desam Party (TDP), staunchly opposing the shift, grapples with the aftermath of the arrest of their leader, N. Chandrababu Naidu, by the state's Crime Investigation Department. This adds to the TDP's woes, as it would have to challenge the government's decision while seeking Naidu's release from prison. Ganta Srinivasa Rao, a former minister and TDP MLA, says, "Capital shift is a ploy to divert people's attention from the arrest of our leader," even as a non-partisan joint action committee prepares to host the 'Visakhapatnam Vandanam' rally on October 15 in support of Jagan's move.

CM JAGAN IS OPTIMISTIC ABOUT THE SC'S DECEMBER DECISION AND IS, THEREFORE, SHIFTING HIS OFFICE FOR A START

Beyond politics, analysts argue that harnessing the strengths of Visakhapatnam—a city chosen by NITI Aayog as one of India's four growth hubs—to establish it as a viable economic and administrative hub makes practical sense. Developing Amaravati would require more than a decade, even if all the resources of the cash-strapped state are pumped into it. "Development will be seen in reality soon. The state government is keen to develop the city on a priority basis," asserts chief secretary K.S. Jawahar Reddy, who on September 23 reviewed the progress of various projects, including the Vizag Metro, National History Museum, Signature Tower and Convention Centre at Kapuluppada, the water park on the Vizag-Bheemunipatnam Road and the Science City on Kailasagiri Hills.

For the administration, the relocation exercise poses several challenges. A state secretariat is yet to be planned. In contiguous Telangana, it took nine years, including the Covid-19 pandemic disruption, for CM K. Chandrashekar Rao to pull down existing structures and invest more than Rs 1,000 crore to build an impressive edifice. For any such grandiose plan, Jagan has to wait for the apex court's decision on the government's right to move the capital.

Jagan is optimistic about the outcome and is, therefore, shifting his office for a start. New seafront blocks being built by the Andhra Pradesh Tourism Development Corporation at Rushikonda are to serve as the CMO and CM's residence. A container substation is being installed, a police station is being set up. There's a catch, though. The report of a high court-constituted committee, in response to a public interest petition against the Rushikonda constructions violating Coastal Regulation Zone norms, is not yet out.

As the high-rises at Rushikonda cannot accommodate all government offices, the idea of repurposing two defunct engineering colleges to serve as the secretariat is being explored with